

*Illustration by* SIDDHANT JUMDE

## WHY NORTH WANTS IT, SOUTH DOESN'T

- Southern states like Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, and Karnataka successfully controlled population growth but now risk losing parliamentary representation as seats are reallocated based on population. Delimitation could diminish their political influence by giving a greater share to northern states with high population growth
- Southern states contribute significantly to India's GDP and tax revenue but may see their share of Lok Sabha seats shrink, leading to questions of fairness in fiscal federalism. Economic disparity is already growing between southern and northern states. Delimitation could deepen this divide, making governance more centralised in the north
- Some southern leaders argue that if LS seats are reallocated by population, the Rajya Sabha should be reformed to give states equal representation regardless of population
- Northern states argue that representation must reflect population size, as per the constitutional principle of proportional representation. Voters in southern states currently have greater representation per MP than in northern states
- States like UP, Bihar and MP have seen exponential population growth but still have the same number of MPs as they did in 1971, leading to severe underrepresentation

population. Economic output, tax contributions and development indicators, they contend, should also be considered. Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) president K.T. Rama Rao insists that delimitation should reflect the fiscal contributions of states. "Take Telangana—it has just 2.8 per cent of India's population but contributes 5.2 per cent of the nation's GDP."

The flip side to this is that the delimitation freeze contradicts the principle of fair representation outlined in Article 81, which mandates that each Lok Sabha MP should represent between 500,000 and 750,000 people. But with the constitutional freeze on seat redistribution since 1976, the average population per constituency has significantly increased, with some MPs now representing nearly 3 million people, leading to severe malapportionment. The impact of delimitation becomes further nuanced when considering the number of registered voters per MP. Northern states have higher under-18 populations, and hence a lower proportion of registered voters per constituency compared to their total population. For instance, in Uttar Pradesh, an MP now represents some 3.1 million people, whereas in Tamil Nadu, it is only 1.98 million. But the difference in actual registered voters per MP is much smaller—around 300,000. Many critics argue that the delimitation freeze has weakened the principle of one person, one vote, which assigns equal weight to each citizen's vote.

The delimitation exercise will also significantly impact the allocation of SC/ST reserved seats in Parliament and state assemblies. Since these seats are allocated in proportion to their population in each state, states with higher SC/ ST growth rates, particularly in the North, could gain more reserved constituencies, while southern states with lower population growth may lose some. According to projections based on the 2011 Census, this could result in a net nationwide increase of two SC-reserved seats and one ST-reserved seat, and at least 18 constituencies witnessing a change in their reservation status. This redistribution could reduce the political influence of SC/ ST communities in states losing seats, triggering opposition from regional leaders.

**THE DELIMITATION EXERCISE WILL ALSO IMPACT THE ALLOCATION OF SC AND ST RESERVED SEATS IN PARLIAMENT AND STATE ASSEMBLIES**

### Collateral concerns

Stalin has expanded his fight beyond delimitation, framing it as a battle for rights, not just numbers. On his birthday (March 1), he declared, "We were pioneers in the language struggle, setting the course for the nation." He sees the three-language policy under the NEP—which he calls